

Overview: Errorless Learning

Errorless learning is about engineering success. You set up tasks, prompts, and environments so that the pupil cannot fail on their first attempts. This isn't about lowering expectations—it's about building a foundation of success that makes harder things possible later. For pupils who have experienced repeated failure, who shut down at the first sign of difficulty, or whose self-belief is fragile, errorless learning rebuilds confidence by proving that they CAN succeed. Once confidence is established, you gradually introduce challenge. But first: success.

When to Use This Strategy

- Says "I can't do this" before attempting
- Stares at blank page without starting
- Shuts down or becomes distressed when faced with challenge
- Avoids tasks they've previously failed

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Identify the failure point

What specific task does this pupil consistently fail at or refuse to try? Be precise—not "English" but "writing opening sentences."

Tip: Look for patterns: where do they shut down, refuse, or consistently get it wrong?

2 Analyse why failure occurs

Is it too many steps? Wrong starting point? Fear of being wrong? Understanding the cause enables you to design success.

Tip: Often the problem is belief, not ability. They CAN do it, but they believe they cannot.

3 Design for 100% success

Make it impossible to fail. Options: give the answer to copy, provide two correct choices, simplify to the point where success is inevitable, or provide full prompts.

Teacher says: "I've set this up so you can't get it wrong. Just follow along."

Tip: The first attempt MUST succeed. No exceptions.

4 Deliver without fanfare

Don't announce "I'm making this easy for you." Just present the task. Let them succeed. Then name their success explicitly.

Teacher says: "You did it. That was you."

Tip: Avoid language that highlights the scaffolding—focus on their achievement.

5 Fade support gradually

Once success is consistent (multiple times, not just once), introduce ONE element of challenge. If they fail, drop back immediately.

Teacher says: "Now let's try a slightly harder one. Same structure, just one more step."

Tip: If in doubt, wait longer before adding challenge. More success builds stronger belief.

6 Track and celebrate progress

Show the pupil how far they've come. This reinforces their growing belief and proves the strategy is working.

Teacher says: "In September, you needed the full answer. Now you're doing it with just the first letter."

English Example: Writing opening sentences

Year 10 pupil stares at blank pages and never starts writing. Every attempt has been "wrong."

Phase 1: No possibility of failure

Teacher: Say: "I've written the first sentence for you. Copy it exactly." Provide the complete sentence.

Pupil: Copies the sentence. Has started their paragraph successfully.

Phase 1: Name the success

Teacher: Say: "You've started your paragraph. That sentence is correct."

Pupil: Experiences success. Brain registers: I can start a paragraph.

Phase 2: Minimal choice, maximum scaffold

Teacher: Say: "Here are two options for your first sentence. Pick one and write it."

Pupil: Chooses one option. Writes it. Cannot fail—both options are correct.

Phase 3: Structured freedom

Teacher: Say: "Start your paragraph with 'The writer...' and say what they do."

Pupil: Writes own sentence using the starter. Has written independently.

Maths Example: Fraction addition

Year 8 pupil shuts down whenever they see fractions. Belief: "I can't do fractions."

Step 1: Give the answer

Teacher: Say: "Add one half plus one half. Here's the answer: two halves, which is one whole. Write it."

Pupil: Copies the correct answer. Has completed a fractions problem.

Step 1: Name the success

Teacher: Say: "You just did a fractions addition. You got it right."

Pupil: Experiences success with fractions—possibly for the first time.

Step 2: Partial scaffold

Teacher: Say: "One quarter plus one quarter. The answer is two quarters. Can you simplify that?"

Pupil: Simplifies to one half. Succeeds with minimal independent thinking.

Step 3: Remove one layer

Teacher: Say: "One quarter plus one quarter equals...?" Wait for response.

Pupil: Says "two quarters" or "one half." Is now doing fraction addition.

Science Example: Equipment identification

Year 7 pupil is terrified of being wrong about equipment names. Gets them muddled and refuses to engage.

Phase 1: Labelled equipment

Teacher: Attach visible labels to each piece of equipment. Say: "Point to the beaker."

Pupil: Points to equipment labelled "beaker." Cannot fail—answer is visible.

Phase 1: Name the success

Teacher: Say: "That's right—it says beaker right on it. You identified the beaker."

Pupil: Succeeds at equipment identification. Anxiety decreases.

Phase 2: Labels removed, chart available

Teacher: Say: "Find the conical flask. If you're not sure, check the chart on the wall."

Pupil: Checks chart if needed. Points correctly. "Good—you confirmed it yourself."

Phase 3: Safe to guess

Teacher: Say: "Tell me what this is. If you're not sure, take your best guess—I'll help if needed."

Pupil: Guesses. If wrong: "Close—it's a measuring cylinder. Now you know."